

The Decision I Need

SUBThe Decision I Need

Dheirav

August 13, 2026

The decision I need

The question

Is "we found *when* this happens" enough on its own to publish, or does the paper need "and here is *why*" first?

Why it is a genuine fork

If "**when**" is **enough**, the paper is close to ready. The claim — that these fairness fixes take opportunities away only when the system is stingy, and hand them out when it is generous — is backed by a clean experiment, checked on 26 datasets, and confirmed on fourteen that were run only after the prediction was written down. What remains is writing, diagrams, and one missing comparison.

If "**why**" is **needed first**, that is a different project. My attempt to explain the flip failed: it passed the test I set for it and was then beaten by a much cruder rule. Doing it properly would need datasets where two things that normally move together can be pulled apart, which is a harder experiment than anything I have run.

What I would argue

The "when" is the contribution, and it stands on its own:

1. **It corrects a well-known claim.** A 2023 Oxford paper put "by default" in its title. It is not a default — it is conditional, and they happened to be working inside the one setting where their version holds.
2. **It is a controlled experiment, not a correlation.** One thing changes and test code verifies that everything else is identical.
3. **It has a practical reading that needs no explanation of the mechanism.** Loans, hiring and admissions are nearly all stingy systems — so the setting where these fixes take opportunities away is the setting they are actually used in.

Plenty of published work establishes when something happens without establishing why.

The objection I expect

That a rule without an explanation is just a curve, and that "somewhere between 0.25 and 0.60" is too vague to act on.

That is fair. My answer is that the *direction* is what changes a real decision, not the exact tipping point — but I would rather be told now whether that holds up than write the paper around it and find out later.

Other questions, if there is time

1. **Which venue, and when?** The deadline decides the page limit, which decides how much of 16 research documents survives into the paper.
2. **One missing comparison.** The closest competing paper implements its fix a different way, and I have never run that version directly. About an hour of work. Worth doing?
3. **AI assistance.** I used an AI assistant substantially — for writing code, running analyses and drafting. What does the department expect me to disclose, and how?

What is not in question

The measurements. Every headline number is regenerated from stored results by an automated check that fails if a document and its data disagree.

Three of my own predictions failed and are written up as failures. Two of my own claims were withdrawn. I would rather be told the framing is wrong now than find out in review — which is exactly what happened with the remedy, and why I no longer claim it as new.